

"I am 100% Original"

Usha Uthup's authorised biography *The Queen of Indian Pop* demystifies the powerful voice that transcended genres and languages. It also reminds us why the 74-year-old singer remains a legend

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

Q+A

Q. How do you look back at your 53-year-long career as a playback singer?
I have had a dream journey. Some of my career's highlights have also been the challenges. For instance, the fact that I was a live performer before I became a playback singer. I come from a time and age when there was only print media and word-of-mouth. So even though people had heard of me, recognition was slow. Then, another challenge was my deep voice, which was so different from others' in the industry. It did limit me from getting more offers in films, but it also slowly turned into a highlight: I am 100 per cent original.

Q. Your biography chronicles your remarkable journey to being regarded as the "queen of pop". What does that phrase signify to you?
It's a bit embarrassing to be called the "queen of pop", although I feel very thrilled to be known as that. Thank god I didn't write an autobiography because I would have never called myself that. I've always believed music is not my business, communication is, and the title makes me feel responsible as a singer to communicate the right signals to people.

Q. You sing in 17 Indian and eight foreign languages. What does it take to master the craft of playback singing in languages not your own?
I work very hard at my languages. I don't just take the trouble to find out the nuances of the specific languages but I also write my lyrics. I make at least three drafts of a song because I feel when you write something out, you remember it better. I also have my own code of how to pronounce certain words.

Q. At this point in your career, what makes you say yes to a project?
Getting a great audience. I don't mean numbers, but just the quality and engagement. And, of course, I would like to be offered good money, too.

–with Poulomi Das